



High ground: World Champion D Gukesh is the No. 1 seed in the tournament. MICHAŁ WALUSZA/FIDE

BATTLE OF MINDS

With Magnus Carlsen absent and **three Indians topping** the seeds, the upcoming World Cup in Goa promises more chess glory for the country.

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The last time India hosted the Chess World Cup — way back in 2002 in Hyderabad — for most people, Indian chess began and ended with Viswanathan Anand, who ended up as the champion at the event. Even ardent sports fans would have struggled to answer if they were asked to name the second-best player in Indian chess.

How times have changed.

The likes of D. Gukesh, R. Praggnanandhaa, Arjun Erigaisi and Divya Deshmukh are now familiar names. They are regularly in the headlines, often for their stunning

achievements on the chessboard in some corner of the globe. And they are all competing at the upcoming Chess World Cup in Goa, at Resort Rio, near Baga Beach.

Chess is indeed a much-changed game in India as the World Cup returns to the country after a gap of more than two decades. Even a casual glance at the list of players would tell you as much: all the top three ranked players in the tournament are Indians.

Gukesh may not be the highest-ranked Indian in the latest ratings released by FIDE — he is, in fact, not even in the top 10. But he is the No. 1 seed at the World Cup. As the defending World Champion, he will be looking forward to this tournament after all the disappointments he has had to face of late.